

KINGFISHERS AND RELATIVES

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This order, Coraciiformes, has a worldwide distribution. All members perch with three toes pointing forward, as do the Passerines, but their two outer toes are fused at the base.

Kingfishers often have bright green or blue colours, created not by pigments but by the scattering of light from the microstructure of their feathers. They follow diverse lifestyles, not all reflected in the popular English name. Fish-eating species locate prey by sight and dive onto it, either from a fixed perch or after a hover in mid-air. Others also hunt land animals, including lizards, rodents, and insects. A large head and a strong neck helps these birds to dive

efficiently, and their sharp-edged, long bill helps grip slippery prey. Fish-eaters have a slender bill, while a broader, scoop-like bill is a feature of woodland kingfishers that catch their prey directly from dry ground. Their short legs are ideal for perching, but kingfishers cannot walk. Their feet are, however, also used for excavating elongated nesting cavities in earth or sand banks.

OTHER RELATIVES

Other members of this order, the American motmots and the Old World rollers, are all land hunters. All kingfisher relatives display a wide variety of bill shapes. In the aerial-hunting bee-eaters, the long bill holds stinging insects away from the head, and is used like forceps to squeeze out insect venom.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	CORACIIFORMES
FAMILIES	6
SPECIES	177



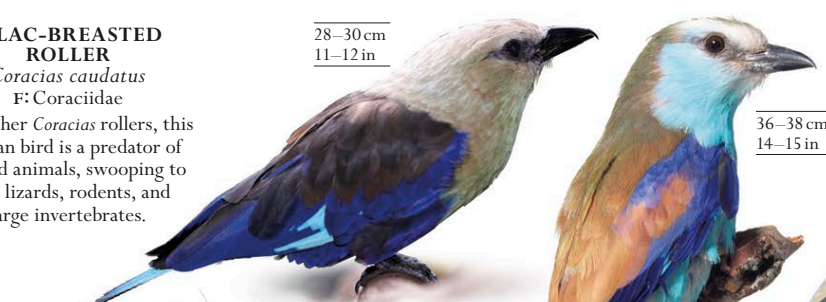
Despite their dagger-like bill, kingfishers grasp prey, rather than stab it, like almost all other fish-eating birds.



LILAC-BREASTED ROLLER
Coracias caudatus
F: Coraciidae

Like other *Coracias* rollers, this African bird is a predator of ground animals, swooping to take lizards, rodents, and large invertebrates.

32–36 cm
12½–14 in



28–30 cm
11–12 in

BLUE-BELLIED ROLLER
Coracias cyanogaster
F: Coraciidae

This C. African roller, like many of its relatives, nests in tree cavities. It is common throughout its extensive range.

36–38 cm
14–15 in



29–32 cm
11½–12½ in

EUROPEAN ROLLER
Coracias garrulus
F: Coraciidae

The most widespread of the *Coracias* rollers, named for their somersaulting courtship displays, this western Eurasian species overwinters in Africa.



36–41 cm
14–16 in

RUFIOUS-CROWNED ROLLER
Coracias naevius
F: Coraciidae

Somewhat dull coloured compared with other species, this large roller inhabits arid areas across sub-Saharan Africa.



DOLLARBIRD
Eurystomus orientalis
F: Coraciidae

Named for its pale, dollar-shaped underwing markings, this roller occurs in woodland from the Himalayas to Australia.

27–30 cm
10½–12 in



BROAD-BILLED ROLLER
Eurystomus glaucurus
F: Coraciidae

Typical of its genus, this African species is longer winged and more agile in pursuit of flying prey than *Coracias* rollers.

27–30 cm
10½–12 in



long, brown tail with dark barring

47–52 cm
18½–20½ in

LONG-TAILED GROUND ROLLER
Uratelornis chimaera
F: Brachypteraciidae

Like other ground rollers, this species from the dry forests of S.W. Madagascar nests in holes excavated in the ground.

black stripe through eye
white throat



PITTA-LIKE GROUND ROLLER
Atelornis pittoides
F: Brachypteraciidae

As the name suggests, ground rollers are mostly terrestrial. This rainforest species is the most brightly coloured of the family.

26 cm
10 in

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